

Intercultural Manager Training Report: US Google Advertising Managers in Japan

Culture, sector, model comparison, risk areas, and practical guideline

Intercultural Competence and Diversity Training

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1 Executive summary

This training is designed for managers from a **United States Google Advertising organization** being assigned to **Japan**. The company culture used as the home-side reference is therefore not a generic advertising agency culture, but a US-based platform business whose commercial role is to **sell advertising space and platform advertising solutions on Google-owned platforms**. The managers are not being trained to “develop campaigns” for advertisers; they are being trained to sell, recommend, support, and govern advertising solutions in a Japanese business environment. This distinction matters because the cultural risk is not only creative execution, but also client trust, platform recommendations, sales promises, stakeholder approval, and brand-safety expectations (Google Partner Marketing Hub, n.d.; Hofstede, 1983, 1984).

The main finding is that the US and Japan are both advanced, achievement-oriented business environments, but they differ strongly in how they handle **context, hierarchy, risk, disagreement, trust, and decision tempo**. US managers are more likely to rely on explicit communication, fast iteration, individual ownership, and short-cycle performance arguments. Japanese counterparts are more likely to expect stronger pre-alignment, formal respect, indirect signals, risk controls, process quality, and reliability over time (Hall, 1976; Hofstede, 1984; Graham & Sano, 1989; Dyer & Chu, 1998; Beugelsdijk & Welzel, 2018).

The practical training guideline is simple: **translate US speed into Japanese-quality process**. For Google Advertising managers, this means every important proposal should be framed as a controlled, well-prepared, stakeholder-safe recommendation: documented rationale, risk boundaries, brand-safety check, approval chain, reporting cadence, and fallback path. Managers should use cultural models as preparation lenses, not stereotypes. Google Japan is not identical to a traditional domestic Japanese company; it is urban, technological, multinational, and shaped by Google’s own organizational culture. The models help managers ask better questions, not label people (Taras et al., 2010; Kirkman et al., 2017; Beugelsdijk & Welzel, 2018).

2 1. Home culture and sector

The home culture is the **United States**, and the sector is **digital advertising / advertising platform sales**. In this constellation, the US organization’s commercial logic is platform-side: managers sell and support advertising products, inventory, audience access, measurement systems, and optimization mechanisms on Google platforms. The training therefore treats “Google Advertising” as a platform and media-sales environment, not as an external creative agency (Google Partner Marketing Hub, n.d.).

The Google brand must be represented accurately. Google’s public brand guidance states that Google’s role should always be shown accurately and that visual or messaging choices should not overstate Google’s involvement or imply endorsement where none exists. It also instructs users not to modify Google logos and to use full-color Google marks on white or black backgrounds where appropriate. This training package follows that logic by using Google-color accents and plain text references, not a modified Google logo or co-branding treatment (Google Partner Marketing Hub, n.d.).

The relevant home-culture management tendencies are: explicit communication, relatively low power distance, strong individual accountability, comfort with debate, optimism about action and optimization, and a tendency to value speed, clarity, and measurable outcomes. These tendencies are supported by Hofstede’s US scores, Hall’s low-context communication model, and the broader management literature on national culture and managerial behavior (Hall, 1976; Hofstede, 1983, 1984; Smith et al., 2002; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.).

3 2. Applying the models to the home culture: United States

3.1 Hofstede

The classic Hofstede profile for the United States shows low-to-moderate power distance, very high individualism, high achievement orientation, lower uncertainty avoidance than Japan, shorter-term orientation than Japan, and higher indulgence. Common training values are Power Distance 40, Individualism 91, Masculinity/Achievement 62, Uncertainty Avoidance 46, Long-Term Orientation 26, and Indulgence 68. The Culture Factor's current online presentation uses some revised labels and values, but the stable training interpretation remains that US business culture tends to favor accessible managers, explicit ownership, debate, initiative, and tolerance for experimentation compared with Japan (Hofstede, 1984; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.; Taras et al., 2010).

For Google Advertising managers, this can produce strengths: clarity, speed, measurable thinking, and ownership. It can also produce risks: pushing decisions too quickly, interpreting hesitation as lack of competence, or framing weak client outcomes as individual failure rather than as a joint process/system issue (Hofstede, 1983; Smith et al., 2002).

3.2 Hall

Hall's model positions the United States as more **low-context** than Japan: meaning is expected to sit in explicit words, direct commitments, and clear written action items. US managers often prefer direct agenda-setting and explicit disagreement when a decision is needed. Hall's chronemics also helps explain the US tendency to treat meetings as decision/action mechanisms, not only as confirmation rituals after prior alignment (Hall, 1976; Nishimura et al., 2008).

For advertising-platform work, this means US managers may present a recommendation as: problem → option → metric → launch. That structure is efficient, but it may under-communicate stakeholder sensitivity, local client context, and risk controls in Japan (Hall, 1976; Graham & Sano, 1989).

3.3 Trompenaars

The US home culture can be interpreted as more universalist, individualist, specific, achievement-oriented, sequential-time oriented, and internally controlled. In practice, US managers may assume that global policy, explicit process, personal accountability, and "fix the system" action language are enough to move work forward (Smith et al., 1995; Smith et al., 2002).

That is useful inside a fast platform environment, but it can clash with host-culture expectations where seniority, face, relationship history, and context-sensitive implementation matter (Graham & Sano, 1989; Smith et al., 2002).

3.4 World Values Survey / Inglehart-Welzel Cultural Map

The Inglehart-Welzel framework distinguishes traditional vs secular-rational values and survival vs self-expression values. The United States is generally treated as a wealthy society with strong self-expression values, individual voice, autonomy, and visible public debate, even while retaining some traditional-value elements compared with parts of Northern Europe (Inglehart & Welzel, 2005; World Values Survey Association, n.d.; Beugelsdijk & Welzel, 2018).

For management training, this reinforces a key home-culture pattern: US managers may assume that open voice, direct feedback, and individual initiative are naturally positive. In Japan, the same behaviors may need different channels and stronger face-saving design (Beugelsdijk & Welzel, 2018; Kirkman et al., 2017).

4 3. Host culture selection

The host culture is **Japan**. The assignment scenario is a US Google Advertising team sending managers to Japan, so Japan is the main host environment. The business context is not tourism or general etiquette; it is

Japanese corporate and client-facing advertising-platform work. The managers will interact with Google Japan colleagues, senior stakeholders, agencies, clients, and possibly multinational teams operating under Japanese business expectations (Graham & Sano, 1989; Dyer & Chu, 1998).

5 4. Applying the models to the host culture: Japan

5.1 Hofstede

Japan scores higher than the United States on power distance and much higher on uncertainty avoidance and long-term orientation. Classic training values are Power Distance 54, Individualism 46, Achievement/Masculinity 95, Uncertainty Avoidance 92, Long-Term Orientation 88, and Indulgence 42. The Culture Factor's current display preserves the strongest contrasts: Japan remains very high in uncertainty avoidance and long-term orientation, and strongly achievement-oriented (Hofstede, 1984; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.).

The management implication is that Japanese business partners may value preparation, precision, role awareness, risk control, group reliability, and reputation protection more strongly than US managers expect. High achievement does not necessarily mean aggressive individual heroics; it may appear as quality, endurance, discipline, and group responsibility (Hofstede, 1984; Smith et al., 2002).

5.2 Hall

Japan is commonly used as a high-context comparison case in intercultural communication. Meaning is often carried through context, relationship history, silence, nonverbal cues, role expectations, and indirect phrasing. A phrase such as "that may be difficult" can carry stronger negative meaning than the literal words suggest. Formality, seating, greeting, and business-card behavior can also communicate respect and hierarchy (Hall, 1976; Nishimura et al., 2008; Graham & Sano, 1989).

For Google Advertising managers, this means that a technically excellent recommendation can still fail if the manager misses indirect resistance, bypasses hierarchy, or forces public disagreement too early (Graham & Sano, 1989).

5.3 Trompenaars

Japan can be interpreted as more particularist/context-sensitive, communitarian in workplace practice, more neutral/formal in business expression, more diffuse in the relationship between role and work setting, more status-aware, and more sensitive to external context and harmony. These are tendencies, not fixed rules, and should be validated locally (Smith et al., 1995; Smith et al., 2002; Taras et al., 2010).

The implication is that global rules must be communicated with local rationale and face-saving implementation. "This is global policy" may be factually correct but socially insufficient. Managers should explain why the policy exists, who needs to be involved, what transition path is safe, and how local risks are handled (Smith et al., 2002; Graham & Sano, 1989).

5.4 World Values Survey / Inglehart-Welzel Cultural Map

Japan is a wealthy, technologically advanced society with secular-rational features, but business communication remains strongly shaped by harmony, order, institutional trust, role sensitivity, and restraint. The WVS lens helps prevent a simplistic "traditional Japan" stereotype while still showing that autonomy, voice, authority, and self-expression may be balanced differently than in the United States (World Values Survey Association, n.d.; Beugelsdijk & Welzel, 2018).

For training, this means managers should not expect every Japanese colleague to be indirect or hierarchy-bound. Instead, they should design channels that work across variation: direct enough for clarity, private enough for safety, and structured enough for consensus (Taras et al., 2010; Kirkman et al., 2017).

6 5. Thorough comparison between home and host cultures

The strongest comparison points are communication, hierarchy, decision process, risk handling, trust formation, feedback, time, and accountability.

First, the United States is more explicit and low-context, while Japan is more implicit and high-context. US managers may seek direct verbal confirmation; Japanese counterparts may communicate reservation through silence, hesitation, deferral, or indirect phrasing (Hall, 1976; Nishimura et al., 2008).

Second, US business culture is more comfortable with accessible managers and open debate, while Japan is more rank-aware and status-sensitive. This does not mean Japanese teams lack opinions; it means the safest channel for disagreement may be private, written, or routed through local leads rather than public confrontation (Hofstede, 1984; Graham & Sano, 1989).

Third, US decision habits often move from meeting to decision to action. Japan often requires pre-alignment before a formal meeting can confirm the decision. Meyer's course framework describes Japan as both hierarchical and consensus-minded; Graham and Sano's negotiation work similarly emphasizes preparation and relationship-sensitive process (Graham & Sano, 1989).

Fourth, uncertainty avoidance is a major difference. US platform culture may normalize pilots, tests, and optimization cycles. Japanese stakeholders may expect more proof, QA, stakeholder approval, and fallback planning before they commit budget or reputation to an advertising-space recommendation (Hofstede, 1984; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.; Taras et al., 2010).

Fifth, trust formation differs. US managers may assume Google's brand, technical expertise, and a strong business case create trust. Japanese relationships may require repeated reliability, careful follow-up, continuity, and fairness before full trust forms. Dyer and Chu's research on supplier relationships in Japan and the US supports the importance of trust mechanisms beyond formal contract logic (Dyer & Chu, 1998).

Sixth, accountability differs. US managers may ask who owns the outcome. Japanese counterparts may interpret outcomes through process, team, role, client constraints, and external dependencies. Smith, Trompenaars, and Dugan show that locus-of-control constructs themselves are culturally sensitive, which supports a more careful approach to responsibility language (Smith et al., 1995).

7 6. Potential problem areas in this specific constellation

7.1 Problem area 1: Misreading indirect communication

A US Google manager may hear "we will consider it" as neutral interest, while a Japanese counterpart may be signaling concern. The risk is that the manager proceeds as if agreement exists, creating later resistance or embarrassment (Hall, 1976; Nishimura et al., 2008).

7.2 Problem area 2: Forcing decisions in the meeting

A US manager may expect a proposal meeting to end with a clear yes/no. In Japan, the meeting may be a visible step in a longer pre-alignment process. If the manager pushes too hard, senior stakeholders may feel cornered and junior colleagues may become silent (Graham & Sano, 1989; Hofstede, 1984).

7.3 Problem area 3: Treating platform pilots like casual experiments

Google's advertising solutions often improve through testing and optimization. In Japan, a pilot may still be seen as a reputational risk if the rationale, quality control, budget cap, and rollback path are unclear. This is especially relevant because Google is selling advertising space and platform solutions, so clients may attribute poor outcomes to Google's recommendation quality (Hofstede, 1984; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.).

7.4 Problem area 4: Public direct feedback

Direct negative feedback may be intended as efficient, but in Japan it can threaten face and status. Saying “this proposal is wrong” in a group setting can damage trust and reduce information flow (Hall, 1976; Graham & Sano, 1989).

7.5 Problem area 5: Individual blame after weak client outcomes

If an ad-space recommendation performs poorly or a client hesitates, US managers may over-personalize the outcome. Japanese teams may expect analysis of process, market context, approval flow, client constraints, and group responsibility (Smith et al., 1995; Smith et al., 2002).

7.6 Problem area 6: Over-reliance on short-term metrics

US managers may emphasize short-term performance metrics and optimization velocity. Japanese stakeholders may need a stronger long-term argument: brand safety, trust, learning, continuity, and client reputation (Hofstede, 1984; Dyer & Chu, 1998).

7.7 Problem area 7: Incorrect use of Google brand cues

Because the managers represent Google, visual and verbal accuracy matters. Training materials should not modify the Google logo, imply endorsement where it is not relevant, or blur Google’s role. This report and presentation use plain-text Google references and color accents rather than modified marks (Google Partner Marketing Hub, n.d.).

8 7. Detailed recommended guideline

8.1 Guideline A: Use “context-first” communication

Before giving a recommendation, state the context, client situation, risk, and stakeholder effect. Replace “Here is what we should do” with “Here is the client context, the risk boundary, the proposed path, and what we need to confirm locally.” This adapts US clarity to Japanese context sensitivity (Hall, 1976; Nishimura et al., 2008).

8.2 Guideline B: Build nemawashi into the operating rhythm

For important ad-space proposals or platform changes, do not wait for the formal meeting. Identify the formal decision-maker, informal influencers, implementation owners, and risk holders. Share the rationale early and resolve objections before the meeting. The meeting should confirm alignment, not create surprise (Graham & Sano, 1989; Hofstede, 1984).

8.3 Guideline C: Make pilots safe before making them fast

Every client-facing pilot should include: business rationale, scope, budget cap, brand-safety/quality checklist, owner, stakeholder sign-off, reporting cadence, escalation trigger, and fallback path. This keeps the US test-and-learn logic but makes it credible in a high-uncertainty-avoidance environment (Hofstede, 1984; Taras et al., 2010; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.).

8.4 Guideline D: Use private, data-first feedback

Correct privately, not publicly. Begin with shared data: “The data suggests this approach creates a risk. How do you see it?” This preserves dignity while still addressing performance. Use problem/process language rather than person/blame language (Hall, 1976; Graham & Sano, 1989).

8.5 Guideline E: Translate accountability into three buckets

For weak outcomes, use three buckets: individual owner, team/process cause, external dependency. This preserves US ownership without creating public blame. It also recognizes that outcomes in platform advertising depend on client readiness, market context, approval processes, measurement quality, creative quality, and platform mechanics (Smith et al., 1995; Smith et al., 2002).

8.6 Guideline F: Lead with respect before expertise

A young or newly arrived US manager may have strong technical expertise, but status and seniority still matter in Japan. Start by respecting local roles, seniority, and context. Then introduce expertise as support for the local decision process, not as a shortcut around it (Hofstede, 1984; Graham & Sano, 1989).

8.7 Guideline G: Treat reliability as trust-building

Punctuality, preparation, accurate notes, exact follow-up, and promise-keeping should be treated as strategic trust behaviors. In Japan, these details signal reliability and seriousness. Trust is built through repeated, consistent behavior, not only through credentials or a strong deck (Dyer & Chu, 1998).

8.8 Guideline H: Use models as hypotheses, not labels

Every training participant should ask: “Is this pattern relevant here, or does Google Japan work differently?” National culture models are useful for preparation, but they do not predict every individual or organization. This is especially important inside multinational technology companies where people may be bicultural or globally trained (Taras et al., 2010; Kirkman et al., 2017; Beugelsdijk & Welzel, 2018).

9 Training-ready final checklist

1. Identify stakeholder hierarchy before the meeting (Hofstede, 1984; Graham & Sano, 1989).
2. Send rationale and risk controls before the meeting (Graham & Sano, 1989).
3. Never treat silence as consent (Hall, 1976; Nishimura et al., 2008).
4. Ask for concerns indirectly and privately (Hall, 1976; Graham & Sano, 1989).
5. Frame ad-space recommendations as controlled proposals, not casual experiments (Hofstede, 1984; The Culture Factor Group, n.d.).
6. Use brand-safety and rollback language in pilots (Hofstede, 1984; Google Partner Marketing Hub, n.d.).
7. Give corrective feedback privately and data-first (Hall, 1976; Graham & Sano, 1989).
8. Separate individual accountability from public blame (Smith et al., 1995).
9. Build trust through reliability and continuity (Dyer & Chu, 1998).
10. Validate cultural hypotheses with local colleagues (Taras et al., 2010; Kirkman et al., 2017).

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